Eòlas vs the market

How Eòlas compares to leading document and knowledge management systems

At a glance

Capability	Eòlas	SharePoint / M365	M-Files	DocuWare	Paperless-ngx	Mayan EDMS	Alfresco
Self-hosted / on-premises	✅	⚠️ On-prem costly	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅
Open source	✅	❌	❌	❌	✅	✅	⚠️ Community
Cloud-agnostic	✅	❌ Azure-tied	⚠️	⚠️	✅	✅	⚠️
Configurable workflows	✅ Linear + Parallel + Conditional	⚠️ Power Automate	✅	✅	❌	⚠️ Basic	✅
Conditional workflow routing	✅ JSON Logic	❌ Separate tool	✅	✅	❌	❌	⚠️
Legal hold	✅ Built-in	✅	✅	✅	❌	❌	✅
Retention policies + alerts	✅ 90/60/30-day + escalation	✅	✅	✅	❌	❌	✅
Document preview (PDF/Office)	✅ pdf.js + LibreOffice	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅	✅
OCR for scanned documents	✅ Tesseract + OCRmyPDF	⚠️ Add-on	✅	✅	✅ Best-in-class	✅	⚠️
AI summaries and metadata	✅ spaCy + LLM	⚠️ Copilot (paid)	⚠️ Add-on	❌	⚠️ ML classifier	❌	❌
Electronic signatures	✅ Click-to-sign audit	❌ DocuSign needed	✅	✅	❌	❌	❌
Public share links	✅ Expiry + password + revoke	✅	✅	✅	❌	❌	✅
Bulk import with CSV	✅ CLI + browser validator	⚠️ Migration tool	✅ Consulting	✅ Consulting	✅	⚠️	⚠️
RBAC with dept scoping	✅ 4 roles + dept admin	✅ Complex	✅	✅	❌	⚠️	✅

Accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA)	✅ Day-one priority	⚠️ Partial	⚠️	⚠️	❌	❌	⚠️
Internationalisation	✅ 23 languages	✅	✅	✅	⚠️ Community	⚠️	✅
Deployment complexity	`docker compose up`	High (Azure AD, infra)	Medium	Medium	Low	Low	High
Licence	Open source	Per-user subscription	Per-user subscription	Per-user subscription	Open source	Open source	LGPL / Paid
Target market	SMB / mid-market	Enterprise	Mid-market / enterprise	Mid-market	Home / small office	Small office	Enterprise

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Why Eòlas exists

Most document management systems fall into one of two camps.

Enterprise systems (SharePoint, Alfresco, Nuxeo) require dedicated IT teams, complex infrastructure, and six-figure licensing. They cover every use case, but at a cost that puts them out of reach for small and medium businesses.

Lightweight scanners (Paperless-ngx, Teedy) handle digitising paper well but stop short of governance. No workflows, no retention, no legal hold, no compliance reporting. Fine for a home office. Not enough for a business with regulatory obligations.

Eòlas sits in the gap between these two. It provides the workflow, retention, and compliance tooling that regulated SMBs need, packaged as open-source software that deploys with a single `docker compose up` command.

Where Eòlas leads

1. Governance without the enterprise price tag

Eòlas ships with per-department configurable workflows (linear or parallel), conditional step routing via JSON Logic, mandatory escalation contacts with configurable deadlines, legal hold that blocks deletion and archiving, and retention policies with approaching-review notifications at 90, 60, and 30 days.

This is the M-Files / DocuWare feature set, delivered as open source. No per-user licence fees. No annual renewal negotiations. No vendor lock-in.

Who this matters to: SMBs that handle contracts, policies, HR documentation, financial records, or regulatory filings and need an audit trail that satisfies ISO 9001, GDPR Article 30, or sector-specific compliance requirements.

2. AI assistance included

Every document uploaded to Eòlas is automatically processed by the AI sidecar:

- **Summaries** generated via configurable LLM (Ollama for on-prem privacy, or Anthropic/OpenAI)
- **Keyword extraction** via spaCy NER
- **Structured metadata** extraction (monetary amounts, dates, parties, jurisdictions, document numbers)
- **Taxonomy classification** against the organisation's own term hierarchy
- **OCR** for scanned documents via Tesseract + OCRmyPDF with 10 language packs

Competitors charge extra for AI features (M-Files Aino, Microsoft Copilot) or don't offer them. Eòlas includes them in the base deployment.

3. Accessibility as architecture

Eòlas was designed for WCAG 2.2 AA compliance from the start. Every interactive element has keyboard navigation, focus indicators, and ARIA attributes. Screen reader users (JAWS, NVDA, VoiceOver) can navigate the full workflow: upload a document, submit it for review, approve it, sign it.

This is not a retrofit. Public-sector organisations in the EU, UK, Canada, and Australia are required to use accessible software. Most DMS vendors bolt accessibility on after the fact. Eòlas was built with it from day one.

4. 23 languages, zero configuration

The UI is translated into 23 languages covering Latin, Cyrillic, Greek, Arabic, CJK, Nordic, Baltic, and Finnic scripts. Language switching is instant. Users pick from a dropdown and the interface updates without a page reload.

Languages: English, German, French, Spanish, Italian, Portuguese, Dutch, Polish, Danish, Norwegian Bokmål, Icelandic, Swedish, Greek, Turkish, Ukrainian, Latvian, Lithuanian, Estonian, Finnish, Arabic, Simplified Chinese, Japanese, Korean.

Who this matters to: Organisations operating across borders. An EU company with offices in Berlin, Paris, and Warsaw can give each team the UI in their language against a single shared document repository.

5. Deploy in minutes, not months

The full Eòlas stack (application, database, search, storage, messaging, authentication, email, AI processing) starts with one command:

```
docker compose up -d
```

No Azure Active Directory. No Oracle database. No proprietary message queue. Every dependency is open-source and containerised. The production deployment profile adds resource limits, TLS termination guidance, and a backup/restore runbook.

Compare this to SharePoint (requires Microsoft 365 tenancy, Azure AD, and typically a consulting engagement) or Alfresco (requires JBoss/Tomcat tuning, Solr configuration, and LDAP integration before the first document is uploaded).

Detailed comparisons

vs SharePoint / Microsoft 365

SharePoint is the default choice for organisations already on Microsoft 365. Its strength is integration with the Office ecosystem: co-authoring, Teams, Outlook.

Choose Eòlas when:

- You want to own your data on-premises or in your own cloud tenancy
- You don't want per-user Microsoft 365 licensing costs
- You need configurable approval workflows without learning Power Automate
- You need retention policies with proactive notifications (SharePoint's retention is label-based and passive)
- Your team is not already in the Microsoft ecosystem
- You serve EU public-sector clients who require open-source or vendor-neutral solutions

Choose SharePoint when:

- Your organisation already has Microsoft 365 E3/E5 licences
- Co-authoring in Word/Excel is a daily workflow
- You need deep Teams/Outlook integration
- You have an IT department comfortable with Azure AD administration

vs M-Files

M-Files is the closest commercial competitor in the governance space. It offers metadata-driven DMS with compliance features, intelligent classification, and workflow automation.

Choose Eòlas when:

- You want zero licensing cost (M-Files charges per named user, typically €40-80/user/month)
- You prefer to self-host rather than depend on M-Files Cloud
- You want to inspect, modify, and extend the source code
- You need a system that deploys in hours, not weeks

- Your AI requirements are served by the included sidecar (M-Files AI features are add-on priced)

Choose M-Files when:

- You need enterprise support contracts with SLAs
- You require integration with SAP, Salesforce, or other enterprise platforms
- You need M-Files' "metadata-only" architecture (views instead of folders)
- Your organisation has 500+ users and an established procurement process for commercial software

vs Paperless-ngx

Paperless-ngx is the most popular open-source DMS for individuals and small offices. It is excellent at scanning, OCR, and tagging paper documents.

Choose Eòlas when:

- You need approval workflows (Paperless has none)
- You need retention policies and compliance reporting (Paperless has none)
- You need role-based access control beyond "can this user see this document"
- You need legal hold (Paperless has no concept of it)
- You need electronic signatures on documents
- You need to share documents externally via secure links
- You have more than one department and need per-department governance

Choose Paperless-ngx when:

- Your primary use case is digitising physical paper (scan, OCR, tag, search)
- You have a single user or a small household
- You don't need approval workflows or retention compliance
- You want the simplest possible setup for personal document archiving

vs DocuWare

DocuWare is a mid-market commercial DMS with workflow automation and electronic signature integration.

Choose Eòlas when:

- You want open-source with zero licence fees
- You want to self-host with full control over your data
- You prefer a modern tech stack (Kotlin/Spring Boot, SvelteKit) over DocuWare's legacy architecture
- You want AI summaries and metadata extraction included, not as a paid add-on
- You need 23-language support without purchasing a language pack

Choose DocuWare when:

- You need native DocuSign/Adobe Sign integration (Eòlas has click-to-sign but not commercial provider integration yet)
- You need deep ERP integration (SAP, Oracle)
- You require commercial support with guaranteed response times
- You need advanced electronic forms with conditional logic (Eòlas has workflow conditions but not a form builder)

What Eòlas doesn't do (yet)

These are capabilities that some competitors offer and Eòlas does not, along with current roadmap status:

Capability	Status	Notes
Real-time co-authoring	Not planned	Use Office Online or Google Docs for co-authoring; Eòlas manages the lifecycle
Native mobile apps	Not started	The web UI is responsive but not a PWA or native app

Commercial signature integration (DocuSign, Adobe Sign)	Roadmap	Click-to-sign audit records are shipped; commercial provider integration is planned
Advanced electronic form builder	Not started	Workflow conditions handle routing logic; a visual form builder is a future consideration
Multi-tenancy	Not started	Current architecture is single-tenant; hosting for multiple customers requires one deployment per tenant
LDAP / Active Directory integration	Designed, not wired	Keycloak supports LDAP federation natively; the connection configuration is a deployment task, not a code task
Email template management UI	Roadmap	Email notifications currently send in English; per-locale template editing is planned

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Technology stack

Layer	Technology	Why
Backend	Kotlin + Spring Boot 3.4	Type-safe, mature ecosystem, strong JPA and security support
Frontend	SvelteKit 5 + Tailwind CSS	Fast, accessible, runes-based reactivity, server-side rendering
Database	PostgreSQL 16	Proven, JSONB for flexible metadata, Flyway for migrations
Search	OpenSearch	Full-text search with relevance scoring, compatible with Elasticsearch clients
Storage	MinIO (S3-compatible)	Self-hosted object storage, API-compatible with AWS S3
Auth	Keycloak 24	OpenID Connect, LDAP federation, SSO, MFA, all configurable via admin console
Messaging	NATS JetStream	Lightweight pub/sub for AI task queue, event-driven architecture
AI	Python sidecar (spaCy, LangChain, Tesseract, OCRmyPDF)	Pluggable LLM provider, on-prem inference with Ollama or cloud with Anthropic/OpenAI
Email	SMTP via configurable gateway (12 provider presets)	Works with any provider; Mailpit for development
Preview	LibreOffice headless (optional sidecar)	Converts Office documents to PDF for in-browser rendering via pdf.js
Orchestration	Docker Compose / Kubernetes-ready	Single-command deployment for dev; production profile with resource limits and TLS guidance
i18n	Paraglide.js	Compile-time message extraction, tree-shaking per language, 23 languages
Observability	Micrometer + Prometheus + Grafana	Custom health indicators for every dependency, pre-built dashboard JSON

Deployment options

Development (local)

```
git clone https://github.com/your-org/eolas.git
cd eolas
docker compose up -d
# Backend: http://localhost:8081
# Frontend: http://localhost:5173
# Keycloak: http://localhost:8180
# Mailpit: http://localhost:8025
```

Production

```
docker compose -f docker-compose.yml -f docker-compose.prod.yml up -d
```

Includes: resource limits, no exposed internal ports, restart policies, mandatory crypto environment variables, TLS termination via reverse proxy (nginx/Traefik/Caddy recipes provided).

Kubernetes

Helm chart is on the roadmap. The Docker Compose services map 1:1 to Kubernetes Deployments + Services.

Pricing

Eòlas is open source. There is no per-user fee, no annual licence, no feature gating.

The total cost of running Eòlas is the infrastructure it runs on:

Deployment	Estimated monthly cost
DigitalOcean Droplet (4 vCPU, 8GB RAM)	~$48/month
AWS EC2 t3.large + RDS + S3	~$120/month
On-premises (existing hardware)	$0 additional
Hetzner Cloud CX31	~€15/month

Compare this to:

- **M-Files**: €40-80/user/month (20 users = €800-1,600/month)
- **DocuWare**: €30-60/user/month (20 users = €600-1,200/month)
- **SharePoint Online**: included in M365 E3 at €36/user/month, but requires the full M365 stack

For a 20-person SMB, Eòlas saves €7,000-19,000 per year in software licensing alone.

Getting started

1. **Try it locally** - `docker compose up -d` and open `http://localhost:5173`
2. **Import your documents** - use the bulk import CLI with a CSV manifest
3. **Configure your departments** - set up teams, workflows, and retention policies
4. **Invite your users** - provision via the admin UI or bulk import CSV
5. **Go live** - switch to the production profile and point your domain at the deployment

Documentation: `docs/` directory in the repository Monitoring setup: `docs/monitoring-setup.md` Backup/restore: `docs/backup-restore.md` Environment reference: `docs/environment-reference.md`

Eòlas (/əʊləs/) - Scottish Gaelic for "knowledge."